

Dominion and the Limits of its Reform

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In *The Lord of the Rings*, Tolkien presents two visions of how humans might relate to the natural world. Saruman's Isengard is surrounded by a landscape stripped bare and industrialized demonstrating dominion as extraction. The Shire is cultivated, bounded, and tended, demonstrating dominion as care. Northcott draws on a thread from Tolkien in *A Political Theology of Climate Change* to argue that dominion can be reformed; he holds up Gandalf as the model: a figure who tends to "all worthy things that are in peril" without claiming ownership over them, declaring "I also am a steward."¹ But Gandalf is not simply a humble groundskeeper; he is a Maia—an angelic being of immense power—who wields the Ring of Fire, inspiring courage and hope in those around him, commands armies, and directs the fates of nations. His stewardship works because he has the authority to back it up, making the two inseparable. This does not invalidate Northcott's use of the image, but it does simply raise a question his account has to contend with: whether a model of dominion grounded in responsible authority can ever fully escape the hierarchical structure that makes the authority possible. I argue that while Northcott traces dominion from its theological roots through its historical corruption and proposes its recovery as covenantal stewardship, his account does not fully resolve the tension this creates, because stewardship continues to depend on forms of human authority that preserve hierarchical relations with nature.

Northcott begins with creation. In Genesis, dominion is given to humans as a covenantal responsibility. It is ordered, relational, and bounded by accountability to God and creation. The Fall disrupts this. "Dominion over nature turns quickly into a curse," Northcott writes, and the consequences are immediate and concrete, "Adam is turned from son of the soil to its servant, toiling in the fields to raise corn and put bread on his table in contest with the weeds."² The image is precise; Adam was not initially placed outside nature but within it as its son—not its master. After the Fall, that relationship becomes distorted. Nature becomes something to be wrestled with rather than participated in, and the human becomes the one doing the wrestling. From there, Northcott goes further: "dominion becomes will to power, empires rise, and the earth as well as humans are subjected to violence and destruction."³ What the Fall introduces, according to Northcott, is not simply a moral failure in individuals but a structural drift in the human-nature relationship itself. It becomes a tendency for authority over the Earth to slide toward domination. This is one of the more compelling claims in his account, and it sets the terms for what follows.

Northcott then traces how this theological drift becomes institutionalized. Francis Bacon "produced the definitive early modern narrative of the purpose of both governmental and science as the advancement of human dominion over the earth through scientific research and technological artifice,"⁴ and this Baconian logic became the animating principle of the modern

¹ Michael S. Northcott, *A Political Theology of Climate Change* (Grand Rapids: William B. Eerdmans, 2013), 108; quoting J.R.R. Tolkien, *The Return of the King* (London: George Allen and Unwin, 1955), bk. 5. ch. 1.

² Northcott, *Political Theology of Climate Change*, 34

³ Ibid

⁴ Northcott, *Political Theology of Climate Change*, 105

state, “the power of the modern nation-state rests upon its power over nature.”⁵ Through Locke and Grotius, dominion gets further embedded in property law, reducing nature to “an objective gathering of ‘things’ available for human use.”⁶ Northcott also notes that Christianity has periodically tried to resist this drift. The Reformation Church pushed back against the commodification of land and human-nature relations, but “the reformers on the whole failed to challenge the growing commodification of land.”⁷ The architects of modern liberalism, despite drawing on Christian moral traditions, “ironically and unintentionally colluded” with merchants and imperial states to dismantle over a millennium of Christian restraints on ownership and wealth accumulation.⁸ The pattern Northcott identifies here is important; structural forces have consistently reasserted themselves even against genuine attempts at reform.

In response, through the text Northcott seems to propose covenantal stewardship—similar to local commons governance—which places theological limits on human sovereignty and emphasizes care for creation rather than extraction from it. He uses the Swiss alpine commons as an example to illustrate this system where we can collectively manage land. The logic behind it is different from private property; authority is distributed, locally embedded, and accountable to the community rather than delegated downward from a state or market.⁹ Northcott’s vision is compelling precisely because it has worked in practice. What remains less clear is how this model might be recovered within political arrangements shaped by the very processes of enclosure and state consolidation he has described. He acknowledges that “the deep roots the dominion of private property in modern political arrangements”¹⁰ presents a serious obstacle, though his account leaves somewhat open how covenantal stewardship might avoid the pattern of absorption he has detailed out thus far.

This is where Tolkien’s own narrative complicates the reading Northcott offers. Northcott invokes Gandalf as a model of responsible stewardship, authority exercised without possessiveness and on behalf of what is fragile. But Tolkien himself treated such arrangements with a degree of skepticism. Gandalf refuses the One Ring not because he lacks good intentions, but because he recognizes that even his good intentions—combined with that level of power—would eventually become dangerous. The corrupting force is not personal weakness—it is structural. Power expands and entrenches itself regardless of the intentions of whoever holds it. This tension is present in Northcott’s own account with every time a reform movement arose to check the drift towards domination, the structural forces would eventually reassert themselves. Responsibility, as Northcott frames it, does not eliminate hierarchy, it arguable presupposes it. The steward still decides what to protect and what to sacrifice, they still occupy a position of authority over nature rather than within it. His critique is powerful on the question of how dominion has been misused, but the question of whether the underlying structure of human

⁵ Northcott, *Political Theology of Climate Change*, 106

⁶ Northcott, *Political Theology of Climate Change*, 141

⁷ Northcott, *Political Theology of Climate Change*, 140

⁸ Northcott, *Political Theology of Climate Change*, 159

⁹ Northcott, *Political Theology of Climate Change*, 135

¹⁰ Northcott, *Political Theology of Climate Change*, 134

authority over nature itself can be ethically justified remains unresolved by the end of his account.

Northcott's account of how dominion became domination traces from the Fall through Bacon to the legal architecture of private property. His proposed recovery of covenantal stewardship is not naïve; it is grounded in real practices and a sophisticated theological tradition. What his account leaves open is whether a framework that preserves human authority over nature, however carefully bounded, can fully address the problem it identifies. There is something telling in how Tolkien's story actually ends that is worth sitting with here. Frodo through his quest does not become a better steward of the Ring; his quest only leads to the destruction of it.¹¹ Whether an adequate response to the ecological crisis requires something analogous, not better management of human authority over nature, but a relinquishing of it, is the question Northcott's account raises but does not answer.

Bibliography

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¹¹ J. R. R. Tolkien, *The Return of the King*, bk. 6, ch. 3.